

least fifty dollars worth of free merchandise. Post offices resorted to hiding their booklets behind the counters, and Sears stores began limiting the amount of coupons that each household could redeem, while the corporate big-wigs in their offices shook their heads in dismay and asked, “What happened?”

What happened was *us*. The Sears Corporation didn’t take into account extreme coupon users. The resulting fiasco could have been avoided in the first place if marketers understood the scope and influence of the select group of people that do not operate like the “average” consumer.

Fast forward to May 2009 when television talk-show host Oprah Winfrey announced that Kentucky Fried Chicken was offering a downloadable coupon good for two pieces of chicken, two side dishes, and a biscuit. More than ten million coupons were printed out. Overwhelmed KFC chains stopped honoring the coupon within forty-eight hours. Allegedly, about 5.7 million people were denied the free meal that otherwise retailed for \$3.99. Lawsuits were filed, and a sit-in erupted in at least one KFC restaurant. While the company offered a rain check, it required customers to apply for their single meal via the Internet. That didn’t placate a lot of unhappy and hungry consumers who not only wanted the free meal they were promised, they wanted free meals for their entire families and all their friends.

“I took my whole family out for a free dinner today,” one couponer reported on a message board I frequented, “And I’m going to do it again tomorrow.”

I could have warned the company what would happen when they distributed a downloadable coupon that could be printed multiple times.